

ducer, *Emergency*, in which she plays former PM Indira Gandhi. It seems all these ventures want to champion female-driven narratives. Be it fascinating character studies—Clean Slate's *Pari* (2018) and *Bulbbul* (2020)—or the telling of real-world stories—*Chhapaak* documents the life of Laxmi, a fearless acid attack survivor—top female actors are today putting their money behind narratives that showcase different aspects of women that have rarely been seen in commercial entertainers until now.

These films showcase aspects of women that have rarely been seen in commercial entertainers



Darlings director and co-writer Reen thinks this is a much-needed move. She didn't expect Bhatt to financially back her script, but was "excited" when it happened. "The best producers are those who empower directors and give them the freedom to do what they want," says Reen. "Producers need the risk appetite. They need to trust somebody's vision, be collaborators and give inputs. Alia always had my back."



While the idea behind *Darlings* convinced Bhatt to take the leap, Pannu wanted to become a producer in order to have more "control" over certain films, especially with regards to "marketing and putting it together". In an interview to INDIA TODAY last year, Pannu said, "I don't want to be called the intrusive actor, but I wanted to be involved at a ground level." She partnered with producer Pranjal Khandhdiya whose two decades of experience and expertise left her confident about Outsider's potential.

Pannu is learning on her new job. Her second film stars Ratna Pathak Shah, Dia Mirza, Fatima Sana Shaikh and Sanjana Sanghi. The film follows these four women on a life-changing journey "to the highest motorable pass in the world", a trip during which they discover how freedom "has to be owned and never given". As the face of many she-centric stories such as *Naam Shabana* (2017), *Saand Ki Aankh* (2019), *Thappad* (2020) and *Shabaash Mithu* (2022), Pannu says she felt she could share with her peers the very opportunities she craves. "I have had these compliments on how brave I was to be doing these films and roles. But when I started pitching them as a producer, I shockingly didn't find as many takers as I thought there'd be. People are a little hesitant to take anything slightly risky." That's not going to deter the likes of Pannu and Bhatt, though. The latter already has her eyes on a script she may not star in but will happily bankroll for another. ■

–Suhani Singh

PRODUCTION POWERHOUSES

Hollywood actresses who are today successful producers

JESSICA CHASTAIN

Run by female executives, Chastain's production company Freckle Films has made movies like *Ava* (2020), *The Eyes of Tammy Faye* (2021) and *The 355* (2022). The Oscar-winning Chastain once said, "I want to see women portrayed like the ones I know—intelligent, strong and vulnerable."



REESE WITHERSPOON



This March, Witherspoon was named the richest actress in the world by *Forbes* magazine, but the actress clearly believes in giving back, too. Launched in 2014, her production Hello Sunshine has bankrolled films like *Gone Girl* (2014) and women-centric shows like *Big Little Lies* (2017-19).

CHARLIZE THERON

Theron's production company, Denver & Delilah Productions, is said to have been named after her dogs. While she has produced many films in which she had a starring role—*Atomic Blonde* (2017) and *Tully* (2018)—she has also produced *Girlboss* (2017), a series in which she did not act.

